Mr. Charles, Currently of Palm Beach

By Paul Rudnick

MR. CHARLES: *(Reads from a letter)* "What causes homosexuality?" *(He puts down the letter)* I do. I am so deeply homosexual, that with just a glance I can actually turn someone gay. *(He glances at someone in the audience)* Well, that was easy. Sometimes, for a lark, I like to stroll through the maternity wards, to upset new parents. I am Mr. Charles, and I am currently residing here in Palm Beach . . . in semi-retirement. In exile. You see, I was asked to leave New York. There was a vote. As revenge, I have begun to broadcast this program on cable channel 47, a show which I call "Too Gay." It can be found at four a.m. on alternate Thursdays, in between "Adult Interludes" and "Stretching with Sylvia." Poor dear.

INTRODUCTION

Mr. Charles is a flaming, fashion-conscious homosexual. On the outside. But as he begins reading letters written to his show, his true self begins to shine through. Mr. Charles, Currently of Palm Beach by Paul Rudnick

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MR. CHARLES: Today's modern homosexuals find me an embarrassment. This is because, on certain occasions, I take what I like to call—a nelly break. *[By nelly break, Mr. Charles means an eruption into the sort of flaming, limp-wristed behavior that for many years was the standard American perception of gay men]* For example: A few months ago, I attended an NYU conference on gay role models. And this young man stood up and said . . . *(In an earnest and manly voice)* "We must show the world that gay people are not just a pack of screaming queens, with eye make-up, effeminate hand gestures,

and high-pitched voices." And I just said . . . *(He does a nelly break, shrieking and mincing and flapping his wrists; he might burble, "oh girl! Oh, Miss Thing! Oh, Mary!" Then he stops, instantly calm again.)* It just happened. I went nelly. I just began babbling, in Gay English. You know, Shebonics.

Oh, or another time, I was attending a rally. And a woman approached me, and she said, "I would like you to donate five thousand dollars, to support our boycott of Hollywood films which portray homosexuals as socially irresponsible, promiscuous, and campy. *(Another delirious nelly break.)* And so I was asked to leave the city.

Since I have begun these broadcasts, I have received many letters and postcards, including this telegram, from the National Gay Task Force in Washington. *(He picks up a telegram from the table)* It reads . . . *(Reading the telegram)* "Dear Mr. Charles. Stop" *(He puts down the telegram)*

I would now like to answer several of the many queries I have received, regarding homosexuality: *(He picks up a letter)* "Dear Mr. Charles, Should gays be allowed to serve in the military?" Oh, no. Congress is absolutely right. You see, I have this military fantasy. *(Mr. Charles acts out his fantasy)* I'm serving in Vietnam, with my unit. And one night, I traipse into the shower tent. It's after hours, and I'm just wearing my kimono, mules and a light moisture pack. And I hear the sound of rushing water . . . and I turn and there at the end of a row of showers stands a naked marine – Colin Powell. His flesh glistens as he lathers up. Finally, I speak. "Hello, soldier," I murmur. "Loofah?" No, darlings, we have no place in

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the armed forces. Make remarks, not war.

(Picking up another letter) "Should gays be allowed to marry?" Of course, wealthy older women.

(another letter) "Dear Mr. Charles, How can I raise gay-positive children in today's political climate?" Well, there are many politically aware children's books, including *Daddy's Roommate* and *Heather Has Two Mommies*. I will soon be publishing my additions to this series. My children's books will include *Uncle Patrick Has a Beautiful Apartment* and *Aunt Cathy 's Large Friend*.

(Another letter) "Dear Mr. Charles, do you enjoy gay theatre?" I am gay theatre. Alright, I will now give you the entire history of American Gay theatre in sixty seconds. Go! *(He free-associate rapidly, using various voices and accents)* "Jimmy isn't like the other boys -- do you know what you are? -- he's no son of mine! I'm just so lonely and sick of my own evil! -- he was a boy, just a boy -- Skipper was my buddy, and our love was pure and strong, but those things they're saying, they're true about me! I'm so sick and ashamed, Karen! Do you know what you are? I am a thirty-two-year-old pockmarked Jew fairy, and that was when my father saw me backstage, in my wig and my tights, and he said, take care of my son. *(Singing)* I am what I am! *(in a gravelly, Harvey Fierstein voice)* I just wanna be loved, is that so wrong? But Doctor, what's wrong with David, with all the Davids? Our people are dying and the mayor still won't even say the name of the disease— *(He raises his arms, as graceful wings.)* Let the great work begin! *(He raises his arms again)* Let the great work

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begin, part two! When you speak of gay theatre, and you will -- be kind. Because it's all about love, valor, baseball and gratuitous frontal male nudity. Bravo! *(Mr Charles bows deeply)*

Which brings us to my favorite part of the program, a forum which I call, "People I Hate." This week's person I hate most in the world is someone I've never even met. His name is Theodore DiBenedetto, and he wrote this letter to the editor of our local paper. *(Mr. Charles reads aloud from a copy of the newspaper, using a butch, manly voice)* "Dear Palm Beach Sentinel, I am a gay man who owns the East Bay Hardware Store." *(He looks up with a withering glance and then continues)* "And I am sick and tired of gay people demanding equal rights when they keep behaving like freaks. As gay people, we must prove that we are not just stereotypes. We must demonstrate that our lives are normal and wholesome. We must show that we can hold jobs, go to church and raise children, just like anyone else. That is how we will earn our place at the table."

(Mr. Charles puts down the paper. He is now dangerously angry, like steel) Darling, I *set* the table. I arranged the flowers. And I would rather have [a] knife at my throat than share even a brunch with Mr. DiBenedetto and his kind. The nice boys. The good citizens. But please, Mr. DiBenedetto, if you'd like, by all means, be normal and wholesome and responsible, get married, have children, move to the suburbs. I'll wait here. Oh, and Mr. DiBenedetto, by the by . . .

(Mr. Charles launches into a viciously savage nelly break. He becomes a ferocious nelly whirlwind, making enormous flamboyant gestures to the audience. He might look into the camera and elaborately mime applying lipstick, and licking his forefinger and slicking each eyebrows).

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Ah, I am the last of my kind. I shall perish, like the dinosaur. Unless of course, Steven Spielberg discovers some ancient DNA and makes more. But let me ask you something. Have you ever been in love? Hands? You see, I fell in love quite early. I must have been, oh, twelve? I had just been savagely beaten by . . . *(He tries to remember, quite cheerfully)* oh it could have been anyone. But this was at school. I came home bruised, caked with mud. I ran up to my room, and I looked in the mirror. And I thought, all right, whom would I rather be? The boys who beat me up, the boys who played baseball and caught frogs and were already losing their figures? Or would I rather be -- Mr. Charles? Who even at twelve knew how to turn his face so the tears would glisten. Who knew enough to immediately put Billie Holiday on the hi-fi, and lip-sync. Who could transform a schoolyard humiliation into an Academy Award. And that was when I fell passionately in love -- with being gay.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Paul Rudnick
Book: The New Century
ISBN: 978-0822223153
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service
Date (Month/Year): 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier